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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: No Date Given

Coverage Date: 1910 AD - 1963 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): BLOOD COVENANT

BLOOD COVENANT

Luguru are said to have made blood covenant with one another; such ceremonies were conducted by joking partners (Christensen, p. 1321).

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[Artificial Kin Relationships](#)

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OFFENCES (One of the few published accounts of punishment of crimes is a short entry in Mzuanda, pp. 145–6; Cory's law questionnaire (ms) contains some information on such crimes, though most serious offences fall outside the sphere of his interest; Morogoro District Book also contains a few manuscripts on this topic)

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A murderer's matrilineage paid the victim's kin a goat in compensation; his kin also were required to pay two persons to the victim's kin who disposed of these as they saw fit. One of the most important rights of a senior matrilineal kinsman was the authority to pawn or dispose of junior kin in compensation for wrongs committed by other lineage members.

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Offenses Against Life

Serious theft was punished by payment of slaves; repeated offenders had their hands cut off.

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Property Offenses

An adultery fine was paid by the offending man to the husband; a fine for illicit intercourse with an unmarried girl was paid to the paternal and maternal kin of the girl who divided this equally. Today, fines of about 30–50 sh. are paid. Adultery, unless repeated frequently, is not grounds for divorce. If a woman's lover desires rights over a child, he must pay (*kuhalalisha*, Swahili) additional cash (the amount is unspecified) to her kin.

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Sex And Marital
Offenses

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Premarital Sex
Relations

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Extramarital Sex
Relations

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Social Placement

BIRTH (Kimmenade, ms; Morogoro District Book; Christensen, p. 1321; Scheerder and Tastevin, pp. 253–4; Mzuanda, pp. 147–8; McVicar, ms)

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Difficult birth is thought often due to a woman's secret sins or adultery and she is urged to confess. The mother and child are confined for a week and the husband is forbidden to see them. On the seventh day, at rites of emergence (*kulawa kunzi*), the mother and child are shaved, rubbed with oil and marked with flour, and the child receives its childhood name. During this period, the husband refrains from intercourse with the wife; authorities disagree about the length of time for this, some giving two months, some over a year during the entire period of nursing.

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Childbirth

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Difficult And Unusual
Births

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Postnatal Care

Pregnant women should not eat certain beans (*kunde*), eggs, twin-bananas, or pregnant animals.

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Avoidance And Taboo

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Pregnancy

One of twins, albinos or breech deliveries were slain by joking partners. Some authorities report that both twins were slain; some that only one. Joking partners were sometimes given children who cut their upper teeth first. Twins and other abnormal persons were disposed of at places (*mahuto*) which were then prohibited from being frequented by others.

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Special Burial
Practices And
Funerals

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Difficult And Unusual
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Abortion And
Infanticide

INITIATION (Scheerder and Tastevin, pp. 260–3; Morogoro District Book: Kimmenade, ms; Christensen, p. 1320; Mzuanda has the most detailed discussion of male initiation (pp. 88–102 and female initiation (pp. 119–32), and of the current rites of circumcision (pp. 13.2–40)

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Puberty And Initiation

The Luguru did not circumcize traditionally, but today the custom is universal. Mzuanda maintains that the practice was introduced from the Sagara about 1910. However, both sexes underwent initiation of some sort even traditionally. In the past boy novices (*wali*) were instructed by an expert (*muhangā*) who told them of proper sexual behaviour and tribal lore. There appears to be extremely wide variation in the details of these rites, both between the various mountain areas and between the mountain and lowland Luguru. This has led to great confusion and complexity in the various ethnographic accounts. Novices were shaved, stripped, kept from bathing and taught about sexual relations. Such instruction and ceremonies were termed *kukula*, *kukola*, *konghongo*, *sae*, *lusona*, etc. Sometimes the boys were confined for long periods indoors in their villages before being taken to the bush for instruction. Later they were decked in new garments, anointed with oil and given 33 new names. Their return to their villages as adults was celebrated by a feast of emergence (*mlao*). Today, circumcision occurs during the period of their instruction in the bush. All such rites take place in the dry season.

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